

ROYA
PUBLICATION

No. 1

SCIENCE FICTION

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THE MEMORY LITURGY

*Beyond the worlds we know—
there are dreams that remember.*

記憶 ¥

HOTEL
AMOR

ホテル愛

浪人食堂

AAA

中央路

RAA

未来は記憶の中に

R X 薬局

X-MALE

white rabbit books

Chew Z

— A ROYA PUBLICATION —

THE MEMORY LITURGY

A Requiem in Twelve Cantos

Chew Z.



A ROYA PUBLICATION

KEY

-  The Gate — where every visitor surrenders a shadow
-  The Library — skulls holding unread memory
-  Tavern of the Unseen — Bahram's wine of memory
-  The River — the mind's own figure, warm as blood
-  Seven Valleys — the pilgrim's road to the Simorgh
-  Shadow Grounds — where surrendered shadows wait
- — the route a pilgrim walks, gate to Simorgh



SI MORGH

the thirty birds
no throne; only golden light
where the river runs

SEVEN VALLEYS

the pilgrim's road to the Simorgh

ESTIGHNA
detachment

TAWHEED
oneness

HEYRAT
bewilderment

FAQR
poverty

FANA
annihilation

ESHQ
love

TALAB
searching



TAVERN OF THE UNSEEN

Bahram pours memory
like wine



THE LIBRARY

skulls of the
unremembered



beasts grazing
on old griefs



THE GATE

shadows
surrendered
here

SHADOW GROUNDS

"like coats no one
has come to collect"



THE MEMORY LITURGY

Roya Publication No. 1

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Synopsis

In the city of Ctesiphon, memory is not private property but a public record, and Cale Rook audits it for a living — deciding, when two people remember an hour differently, whose version the record will keep. Then an envelope arrives bearing his own photograph, and seven months of his own disappearance.

What begins as an ordinary case unravels into a passage between two worlds: the rain-lit streets of the waking city, and a walled town beyond sleep where every visitor surrenders a shadow at the gate, and grief is read from the skulls of the unremembered. Guided by an ageless wanderer in green, taught by a tavern-keeper who pours memory like wine, and hunted by a Reconciler sworn to erase every doubt that threatens the Concern's fragile peace, Rook must cross seven valleys of an old, old story to learn whether he is the man who vanished — or only a faithful echo, carrying someone else's grief forward as his own.

The Memory Liturgy is a noir hallucination about

*memory, identity, and what we owe the people who
witnessed us honestly — and what is left of a self,
once the story it was built on refuses to hold.*

A Note from the Author

None of us chose the memories we started out with. A name, a language, a grief that belonged to a parent before it ever belonged to us — we inherit these the way we inherit a house we didn't build, and we spend the rest of our lives deciding how much of it to keep. *The Memory Liturgy* takes that ordinary fact and asks a harder question of it: what if a memory could be handed to someone even more directly than that — not shaped by upbringing, but placed there whole, by someone else's grief, someone else's need to keep a person alive a little longer than the world was willing to allow?

Cale Rook spends most of this book believing his task is to find out whether he is an original or a copy — a question with exactly two answers, both of them lonely. The book's actual position is that this was always the wrong question. A memory doesn't stop being real because of where it came from. It becomes real the moment someone agrees to carry it forward, honestly, at some cost to themselves. That is the entire mechanism the novel is built around: not a debt owed to an institution, but the older, plainer obligation we owe to anyone who has ever witnessed us truly — to keep carrying what they gave us, even

after they're gone, even when it was never technically ours to keep.

Farrokh Nassar is the character who carries this idea furthest. He spends eleven years enforcing an institution's right to erase inconvenient memory, while secretly keeping one memory alive that the institution had already declared closed. His arc isn't really about guilt. It's about the specific, quiet defiance of deciding that some memories are worth keeping regardless of who has the authority to say otherwise.

The seven valleys, the Simorgh, the birds who discover the king they sought was only themselves, counted together — all of it points at the same idea from a different angle. A self is not a single, verified account of one person's history. It's whatever memories a person is still willing to carry, however many hands they passed through to get there. That's the liturgy the title is naming: not a rite performed by an institution, but the ordinary, repeatable act of choosing to hold onto what someone else needed you to remember.

— *Chew Z.*

Contents

*Each canto is marked by where it takes place: **THE CITY**, the waking world the narrator lives in, or **THE MEMORY LAND**, the walled dream beyond it where every visitor leaves their shadow at the gate.*

I	The Office on Quiet Street	
	THE CITY	11
II	The Reconciler	
	THE CITY	14
III	The Gate, and the Guide Who Waits There	
	THE MEMORY LAND	17
IV	Anahita Vey and the Coastline	
	THE CITY	20
V	The Tavern of the Unseen	
	THE MEMORY LAND	22
VI	Dariush, Who Was Built to Remember Someone Else	
	THE CITY	24
VII	The Reconciler's Price	
	THE CITY	26

VIII	What Arrived Without Being Asked	28
	THE CITY	

IX	The Conference of the Thirty	31
	THE MEMORY LAND	

X	The Scar	35
	THE CITY	

XI	What We Remembered Together	37
	THE CITY	

XII	The Wall, Where Both Worlds Meet	40
	THE THRESHOLD	

CANTO I

THE CITY

The Office on Quiet Street

The city of Ctesiphon didn't have weather anymore. It had *moods* — a slow, citywide shift in light and humidity that the Concern's engineers called "ambient consensus drift" and that everyone else just called Tuesday, or a bad week, or the blues. I'd stopped asking why years ago. You live somewhere long enough, you stop needing the mechanism explained to you, the same way you stop needing to know how your own heart works in order to trust it'll keep going.

My office was on Quiet Street, above a pawnshop that never seemed to open, and I did the kind of work nobody wants explained to them at a dinner party: I audited memory for the Concern — the institution that had decided, generations ago, that memory could not be left in private hands the way money once was. Every memory of consequence had to be registered, and when two people's accounts of the same hour disagreed, an auditor settled which version the record would keep. When two people disagreed about what had actually happened between them, I was the one who sat with both

versions until I could tell you which one was true. It is a smaller, sadder job than it sounds. Mostly I just watched people cry over things they already knew.

My name, on the license the Concern issued me, is Cale Rook. It had not always been my name. I was born, in a life I remember only the way you remember the smell of a house you left as a child, Soroush — a word that in the language of my grandmother's grandmother meant something like *the one who listens*, or *the message that arrives after the messenger is gone*. The Concern doesn't ask you to give up a name like that all at once. It asks for small pieces of it, in exchange for licenses, for housing, for the right kind of memory-clearance to do the only work you're any good at, until one day you notice the name on your door doesn't sound like anything your mother ever called you across a courtyard at dusk, and you've stopped being able to say exactly when that happened.

There is a memory I carry from that name, though, that doesn't behave like the others. Most of what's left of Soroush comes to me the way old photographs come to you — flat, captioned, a little unconvincing. This one has weather in it. It has a smell. I am very young, and it is very hot, and I am lying on a flat roof under stars that have not yet been engineered into anything, and an old woman's voice — my grandmother's, though I could not draw her

face for you if my license depended on it — is telling me about a mountain called Qaf, and thirty birds, and a king they crossed the whole world to find. *You already carry a piece of the king in you*, she says, in a language I no longer speak awake. *You'll spend your whole life forgetting that. If you're lucky, something will remind you.*

I did not, at the time I received the envelope that starts this account, understand that I was being asked to investigate myself, or that the old woman's voice was about to become the least provable and most important thing in the whole case. I made coffee. I filed the photograph. That night I dreamed, for the first time in longer than I could account for, of a river I had never seen and a wall I somehow already knew the exact height of, stone by stone, and of a bird with a long curved beak standing at a crossroads in green robes, waiting, the way old friends wait, for someone slow to catch up.

I have learned, since, not to call that kind of dream *just* a dream.

CANTO II

THE CITY

The Reconciler

He was waiting in my office when I got back from the coffee cart, sitting in my chair like a man who had never once in his life needed to ask permission for a chair.

"Farrokh Nassar," he said, not standing. "Reconciliation Office." He set a card on my desk, the Concern's seal pressed into it so hard it had left a shadow on the wood beneath. "You'll have heard of us the way people hear of weather systems. Something that happens to other cities."

I hadn't heard of them, and I told him so.

"Good," he said. "That means you haven't done anything yet that required us." He was younger than his voice, older than his eyes, and he looked at me a moment longer than the conversation required — the way you look at a word you're almost certain you've misread. "I'm told you opened a file on a missing auditor named Cale Rook."

"I am Cale Rook."

"That's the file I'm here about." He said it gently, the way you'd tell a man his reflection had started arriving in mirrors a half-second before he did. "The Concern does not enjoy it when an auditor discovers he might be a *continuity-vessel* — a mind grown and loaded with a dead man's memories, wearing the dead man's name and badge — investigating his own disappearance. It creates what my office calls a *reconciliation event*: a discrepancy between the story the city has agreed to and the story a specific pair of eyes is starting to see instead. Left alone, it doesn't stay contained. It spreads. People start dreaming of walls they've never seen."

I asked him, carefully, how he already knew about Anahita Vey, and about the man on Quiet Street's low end.

"Because reconciling this file is my job, and I am, whatever else you think of me, extremely good at my job." He stood, finally, taller than the chair had let him seem. "I'm not here to stop you investigating, Rook. I'm here to tell you the Concern gives you thirty days before it reconciles the discrepancy itself — by collapsing it down to whichever version of the story costs the fewest people their sleep. In my experience that version is rarely the one where the auditor gets to keep both his names."

He left a second card on the desk before he went, this one blank, and told me, over his shoulder, in a voice gone almost kind: "Find your shadow before I have to. I would rather not do this to a countryman."

I did not, until much later, understand what he meant by that last word, or why it lodged in my chest like a stone dropped down a well whose bottom I couldn't hear. That night, for the first time on purpose instead of by accident, I let myself go looking for the wall from my dream.

CANTO III
THE MEMORY LAND

The Gate, and the Guide Who Waits There

There is a town at the edge of what I am, walled entirely round, that I visit when the drug called Verity — the sacrament the Concern issues its auditors, that lets one mind briefly hold another's memory as though it were its own — runs deep enough in my blood to loosen whatever keeps a mind in one country instead of two.

The Gatekeeper wore green the color of water seen through ice, and he did not ask for papers. He asked for your shadow.

"Everyone who enters leaves it at the wall," he told me, sharpening a long curved blade against a whetstone with the patient, uninterested rhythm of a man who has done this so many times the motion has stopped requiring him. "Your shadow will weaken out there, cut off from you. Eventually it will die. A mind cannot hold both its grief and its rest at once. You'll find you don't miss it, in time. Almost no one does."

I asked him what people called him.

"Different things, in different mouths," he said. "Names are the coat travelers put on me to keep from feeling how old the road actually is. You may call me whatever helped you sleep, before you started dreaming of walls instead."

Beyond the gate the town kept a silence so complete it had texture — streets of pale stone, a clock tower with no hands, a river that ran the same temperature as blood, and, grazing along its banks in the low gold evenings, golden-maned beasts with a single horn, who did not eat grass so much as they ate what the townspeople could no longer bear to carry.

I was given work in the Library at the center of the town — not a library of books, but of skulls, old and dry and faintly luminous, each one holding a single person's unread memory. I was told I had the training to read them. I did not remember acquiring it.

"One more thing," the Guide said, as I turned to go, and for a moment I thought I saw, folded into his raised hand like a coin trick, a bird's dark curved silhouette. "Everyone who enters this town is looking for something they've decided is very far away. Almost none of them are right about the distance. And some of them," he added, so quietly I nearly missed it, "are not entirely looking for themselves."

I woke with his words still turning in me, and
went the next evening to Anahita Vey's door,
wondering whether she too had started dreaming of
the same wall without a name for it.

CANTO IV

THE CITY

Anahita Vey and the Coastline

Anahita Vey worked out of a rented room above a print shop, drafting survey maps for colonial contracts nobody in Ctesiphon would ever see finished. She had kept, from a life folded up before the Concern's filing began, a habit of pouring a thimble of water onto every new map before she began it — for the sea that would eventually erase the paper, so the paper would know in advance not to take itself too seriously.

When I told her why I'd come, she reached for a pencil and began, unasked, to draw a coastline from memory — a long, tide-broken shoreline that existed on no map she owned.

"Susa-9," she said, not looking up. "I surveyed it for six years. Fell in love with an inlet the way some people fall in love with a person. I filed the elevation data fourteen months before the terraform crews came through. Nobody read it. They flattened the whole coast in eleven days, because it was faster to ask the woman standing next to the map than to

open the file she'd already given them."

"Cale Rook came to me eight months ago," she said, before I asked, "auditing the Susa dispute. He asked exactly nothing about the contract — and then he asked anyway, like he already suspected the contract was the wrong question." She looked up. "You didn't ask me about the contract either."

I hadn't noticed I'd skipped it. This is the trouble with Verity: it stops being clear which reflexes are yours and which ones you borrowed from a life you don't remember living.

I told her about Nassar, and about the thirty days, and watched something in her go very still, the way water goes still right before it decides whether to freeze.

"I dream of the wall too, Rook — have for years, since Susa. I've felt my own grief being eaten by something gold and single-horned, some nights, so I can keep coming to work without screaming." She set down her pencil. "There's a word my grandmother used, for the ache of missing a home you were never allowed to see get old. *Ghorbat*. I think that's what this whole city actually is, underneath the maps. *Ghorbat*, with better lighting."

CANTO V
THE MEMORY LAND

The Tavern of the Unseen

Down a lane the color of old bruises, past a wall inscribed in a script none of the Dreamreaders could translate, was a low tavern with no sign, run by an old man everyone called the Moghan — a word for the keepers of a certain kind of wine that had nothing to do with grapes and everything to do with what a person is willing to stop pretending, after the second glass, that they still believe about themselves.

His name was Bahram, and he poured from a vessel that never seemed to run empty and never, so far as I saw, was refilled.

"You're the one auditing his own disappearance," he said, setting a clouded glass in front of me. "It goes down like memory, because it is memory — other people's, mostly, distilled past the point where it minds being drunk."

"Nothing here is safe," he told me, when I asked. "Safety was left at the gate with your shadow. What it is, is *true* — a different, older kind of safety, if you learn to drink it slowly." He nodded toward the

corner, where townspeople turned in a slow unhurried circle, robes lifting like the vanes of some patient machine measuring a wind none of the rest of us could feel. "They're emptying, not dancing. A cup has to be hollow before it can hold anything worth holding. Most of what passes for a self is just an elaborate, frightened way of refusing to be hollow."

I drank. It tasted the way Anahita's coastline had felt in my chest — vast, and lost, and not entirely mine, and worth grieving anyway. But underneath it, that night, I tasted something else too: a grief with less salt in it and more smoke, folded so closely into my own that I couldn't find the seam.

"A student once asked an old teacher of mine how to find what he'd lost," Bahram said, "and the teacher only lifted one finger and pointed at the moon. The student spent the rest of his life admiring the finger. Do not admire the finger, Auditor." He refilled a glass that had not been emptied. "I will say one more thing, though it isn't mine to explain. I have poured for a great many auditors. I have never once poured for only one man in a cup that size."

CANTO VI

THE CITY

Dariush, Who Was Built to Remember Someone Else

Dariush worked nights at a memory-parlor on the low end of Quiet Street. He had been grown — the polite word was *continuity-vested* — to carry forty years of a dead industrialist's memories forward for the man's heirs. His own chosen name, in the same old tongue as mine, meant *possessor* — a joke he made about himself before anyone else could.

"I woke up four months old and already married," he told me, over bad coffee. "You get used to it the way you get used to a bad knee. You don't heal it. You just learn which stairs to avoid."

I told him what Bahram had said — that the cup I'd been given seemed too full for one grief. Dariush went quiet.

"That isn't how it's supposed to work," he said. "A vessel carries one file. One residue, sealed and dated. If you're carrying two that don't match, somebody did that on purpose. Somebody with clearance to touch a sealed file twice." He turned his cup a slow half-circle. "There's an old story — a

guide in green, and thirty birds looking for a king called the Simorgh, past seven valleys nobody survives with the self they started with. In the old language, *si morgh* means thirty birds, and Simorgh is only that phrase, reshaped. They spend the whole story hunting a king who turns out to be nothing but the thirty of them, seen at once, in the right light." He looked at me, nothing borrowed in his eyes. "I think that's the only real answer about the scar, Rook. But you should stop asking whether you're the original. Start asking how many people you might actually be."

CANTO VII

THE CITY

The Reconciler's Price

Nassar found me on the twelfth day, on Anahita's stairwell, waiting the way men like him always wait — without impatience, because impatience would have meant doubting the outcome.

"Eighteen days remain," he said. "I've decided to spend one of them telling you plainly what reconciliation costs, since nobody in my line of work ever does that courtesy for the people about to be reconciled."

"When the Concern collapses a discrepancy, it doesn't merely erase the auditor's doubt," he said. "It erases every witness who helped him hold it. Your cartographer's coastline-grief — reconciled. Your industrialist's borrowed son, and the joke he makes about his own name — reconciled. Not killed. *Smoothed*. Made no longer any trouble to anyone." He said it without cruelty, which was worse. "I have done this work eleven years. Before the Concern gave me this rank, my mother called me by a word that meant *fortunate* — Farrokh — because she was almost certain no child of hers would ever need luck that badly. I have spent every year since finding out

how wrong a mother's hope can be and still be forgivable."

He was not looking at me the way a Reconciler looks at a file. He was looking at me the way you look at a photograph you weren't expecting to find in a drawer you'd stopped opening years ago.

"You're one of us," I said. "A continuity. Or a man who gave up his name the same slow way I gave up mine."

"I am the Concern's answer to men like you," he said — an actual hesitation cracking through, the first I'd seen in eleven days. "You have eighteen more to decide whether you agree with me. I hope you don't. I have not hoped that about anyone in longer than I can comfortably admit."

He left me with a second feeling underneath the eighteen days, one I didn't yet have language for — that whatever he was hunting me for, it was not entirely the reason his badge said it was.

CANTO VIII

THE CITY

What Arrived Without Being Asked

I want it on the record — if a record is still the right word for what I'm doing now, writing this long after any office stopped asking me to — that I did not go looking for what came next. It arrived the way weather arrives. Not solved. Not summoned. Simply, suddenly present, the way you look up from a book and realize it has been raining for an hour, and that some part of you knew before you looked.

I was in my office past midnight, doing nothing more purposeful than failing to sleep, when a courtyard opened underneath me — the way a trapdoor opens under a man who has spent his whole life assuming the floor was only ever the floor.

A fig tree. A roof, and stars that had never been engineered into anything. My grandmother's voice, teaching me a word for grief that had no clean translation into anything the Concern would later let me keep. And then, without transition, without the courtesy of a door between one memory and the next, a smaller room — antiseptic, machine oil, a

window with a view of nothing — and a boy perhaps two years older than me, holding my hand, reciting the story of the thirty birds from memory because I had asked him to, because I could not sleep, because our father was three days dead in a fire on a station whose name I could still taste in my mouth like copper. He got to the part where the king turns out to be the birds themselves. He always did. It was the only part he trusted himself not to get wrong.

I don't know how long I sat with that before I understood I was no longer only remembering it. I was inside it the way you are inside your own name — not observing, wearing.

Somewhere underneath the fig tree and the antiseptic room, quieter than either, a third thing was also true, and I let it sit there unexamined for a while longer than I should have, the way you let a bruise go unpressed because you already know, before you press it, exactly how much it's going to hurt: that whatever I had just remembered did not fit inside the file a dead auditor named Cale Rook would ever have been issued.

I did not go to the wall that night. I sat instead in the dark with the specific, quiet vertigo of a man discovering that the grief he'd spent two weeks assuming was his private inheritance might, in fact, be someone else's — riding inside him like a

passenger who'd boarded before he ever woke up enough to notice the extra weight.

I thought of Nassar's face on the stairwell. Not the face of a man reading a file. The face of a man who had opened a drawer he'd stopped opening years ago, and found the photograph still there, waiting, exactly where he'd left it.

CANTO IX
THE MEMORY LAND

The Conference of the Thirty

The Guide met me without his blade, and instead of asking for my shadow — already long since surrendered, still waiting somewhere west of the wall — he asked me to walk with him, through streets I had read a hundred skulls' worth of grief along and never once actually seen.

"There is a road past the Library, through seven valleys, that ends at the court of a king called the Simorgh," he said. "Every pilgrim believes, at the start, that the king is very far away and very separate from the one walking toward him. Almost none of them are right about the distance. And almost none of them," he added, "walk it carrying only one grief, however much they'd prefer to believe otherwise."

We passed through valleys I can describe now only the way you describe a fever afterward — not as events, but as temperatures.

A valley of *Talab*, searching, where I walked past every version of myself that had ever wanted the

wrong thing badly enough to call it a calling — and past, too, a boy searching a station corridor for a father the fire had already taken. A valley of *Eshq*, love, where I understood that the coastline I'd felt in my chest since Anahita first gave it to me had stopped, somewhere along this road, being only borrowed — that grief carried far enough, by however many hands, becomes a shared thing, the way a scar becomes skin regardless of whose skin it started as. A valley of *Estighna*, detachment, where I set down the need for the world to agree with my account of myself, and found, underneath it, that I no longer entirely wanted to be only myself, if being only myself meant leaving someone else unclaimed. A valley of *Tawheed*, oneness, where for the length of one held breath I could not locate the border between my walking and the Guide's, between the boy on the roof and the boy in the hospital room and the man who had spent eleven hard years erasing people for a living because he had once begged an office exactly like his own for a mercy it did not have the discretion to grant. A valley of *Heyrat*, bewilderment, where every answer I'd gathered dissolved back into questions, and I was, for the first time since Nassar's card landed on my desk, at peace with not knowing which of us the question belonged to. And at the last, a valley with no name I was given, only an old word Bahram once used for the hollowed cup — *Faqr*, poverty, and past it, folded so closely

into the same breath it barely counted as a second word, *Fana*: the annihilation that isn't death, only the stopping of the argument over which version of you gets to be real — and over how many of you there were to begin with.

At the end of the seven valleys there was no throne, no king, no shape more solid than the golden evening light the single-horned beasts grazed in along the river. There were only the birds who had made the crossing — thirty of them, or one of them wearing thirty shapes, I no longer trusted my eyes to say which — and among their number, unmistakably, my own surrendered shadow, seven months older and immeasurably less afraid.

It was not alone. Beside it, or perhaps within it — the light in that country has never agreed to be precise about where one grief ends and another begins — stood an older shape, worn the particular gray of something that has been standing outside a wall for far longer than seven months.

Si morph, the Guide said, and did not let the silence do the translating alone this time. "Thirty birds, Auditor. Not thirty selves. Thirty griefs, however unevenly distributed among however many bodies agreed to carry them."

I asked my shadow what it had been keeping, out there, all that time. And the current that shadows speak in — single, unbroken, incapable of the small mercy of a pause — answered with two names where I had only ever expected one.

Soroush, it said first, and I felt the word land the way it always had — water reaching a root that had been waiting years for rain.

Then, quieter, older, worn down to something nearer a smell than a sound: *And Soroush*, it said again — the same syllables, carrying now a second boy's weight inside them, kept alive against every incentive an entire institution had given someone to let him go, hidden inside a stranger's file because a stranger's file was the one place left in the whole Reach where a certain kind of man was still permitted to grieve without anyone asking him to reconcile it.

I did not wake from that valley understanding whether I was the man who'd vanished. I woke understanding, finally, that the question had never had a singular answer to find.

CANTO X

THE CITY

The Scar

I went, before I had fully decided to, to the parlor where Dariush worked, and rolled up my sleeve in the dim red light without being asked why.

There was nothing on the inside of my left wrist. No burn, no scar — just skin, unmarked by a fire I could still describe in more detail than my own mother's face, a fire I understood now had not happened to Cale Rook at all, and had not, strictly, happened to me either.

Nassar came that evening, and found the three of us together — Anahita, Dariush, and I — in the print-shop room that smelled of pencil shavings and old paper. He had come alone every night. I understood now, watching him in the doorway, that whatever this had cost his office to conceal, he had spent it alone, the way you spend something you can't file an expense report for.

I did not say what I'd rehearsed saying. I rolled my sleeve back down, slowly, the way you close a door you've decided not to slam, and looked at him the way you look at a name you've only just learned

how to pronounce.

He understood before I said a word. Understanding, in that room, arrived the way the fire itself must have — total, instant, nothing left to negotiate with. He did not confess, not in any shape a courtroom would recognize as one. He only rolled up his own sleeve, without being asked, and let the scar do what eleven years of rank had never once let him do on its own.

Raised. Pale. Precisely where mine should have been.

CANTO XI

THE CITY

What We Remembered Together

N assar did not tell me the rest of it. That is not quite what happened, and I have decided, writing this, that the distinction matters.

He sat in the chair nearest the door, the way a man sits when he has been standing for eleven years and has finally been given permission to stop, and he said almost nothing at all — a handful of words, no more, offered the way you set down something heavy rather than the way you hand something over. And around those few words, the rest of it simply rose in me, unbidden, the way the fig tree had, the way the hospital room had — because by then it was not a story I was being told. It was a memory I already owned, and had simply never been permitted to open.

I remembered — as my own, because by then it was — the week the registrars came, brisk and almost kind, to catalogue what our father's death had left behind, including the boy who was going to die more slowly beside it. I remembered how fast they

were about the father's record, and how slow the same office became when a brother was fading by inches instead, as though a slow dying were a lesser emergency, a different department, a case that could wait. I remembered an older brother joining that office not out of ambition but out of the particular desperate arithmetic of a person who believes he can work a mechanism faster from inside it than he can survive it from outside — and I remembered, though this part came to me the way a bruise comes back when you press it, exactly on cue, exactly where you knew it would hurt, the morning the file was closed before he'd finished asking for more time. I remembered not being permitted to keep so much as a photograph. The Concern does not return a record once it has been sealed.

Somewhere in the room, in the present tense I still had to keep one hand braced against to remember it was the one I actually lived in, Nassar said only: "Eleven years." And then, later, smaller: "I kept what I could. Illegally. The way a man keeps ash he was never issued an urn for." And once, near the end, not quite a question: "I hoped you'd hold both of us. I never knew it. There is no protocol for what I did."

I did not ask him whether he had lied about the thirty days. I already knew he hadn't — that the clock had always been real, that the only lie in the whole

eleven days had been about which of us he was actually racing it to save.

Anahita asked, very quietly, what would happen to him now, if this came out.

"I no longer especially care," he said, "provided it happens after, and not before, I've been allowed to sit in a room where somebody finally remembers my brother's name without needing it explained to them first."

I told him he could come as far as the wall.

CANTO XII

THE THRESHOLD

The Wall, Where Both Worlds Meet

N assar could not cross the gate the way I did — the Concern's sacrament had never been issued to Reconcilers, whose work depended on never once doubting which side of a story they stood on — but he could stand at the threshold with me, in the strange half-light where the City's dreaming edge and the Memory Land's waking one overlap.

My shadow was waiting west of the gate, in the field where the resigned ones lay like coats no one had come to collect, the only one still willing to rise when it saw me coming. It had not, I understood now, been alone in any way that mattered for a great many years.

I want you to stop asking the wall to decide who's real, it said, in the single unbroken current shadows speak in, and I understood, this time, that the voice was made of more than one grief agreeing to share a register. There were never only two of us. We're both — all of us — what's left after a city spends generations deciding whose pain counts enough to

keep. Take the weight back if you want it. We're tired. But take it back because it's yours either way — ours, now — and it's better carried by hands that know each other than by one hand pretending it was ever whole.

I asked whether it still wanted to be called by the name it had given me twice.

Sorouch, it said, and I understood, without needing to be told, that it was answering for both of them at once — *si morgh* had always been two words wearing one sound. *The one who listens. Neither of us stopped. We only stopped being asked.*

I don't know whether I walked back through that gate a man reunited with his shadow, or a continuity finally honest about how many people it had quietly been asked to hold. I know only that I woke on Quiet Street with nothing in me flinching at a stair that wasn't there — and that nearer than any wall, in a doorway I'd left a few hours before, a man who had spent eleven years being the hand that closed other people's wounds had finally let someone close his.

Anahita stopped signing her maps with the names of women she used to be. Dariush kept his second ledger, and started a third for a joke that had stopped needing to be one. Nassar's office never came for any of us again. I heard, months later, that

he had taken three consecutive days of leave — the first in eleven years — and spent them on a rooftop in the old quarter, in weather the Concern had not engineered, under stars arranged for no one's convenience.

I closed the file the way I closed every file that job ever gave me — not by proving whose version of the truth was correct, but by writing, in handwriting I no longer check against anyone else's, under a name I have started, slowly, to let people use again: *Subject found. He had been west of a wall the whole time, waiting to be asked back in — under both of our names — by someone finally patient enough to listen for it.*

That was always the entire liturgy. Not the town, not the city, not even the long road through seven valleys to a king who was only ever the pilgrims counted together, however unevenly the counting had been done to them. Only the willingness to walk between all of it, and claim, at last, the whole of what you'd been carrying — even the parts, especially the parts, that were never only yours to begin with.

*— *END* —*

— **END** —

A Note on the Simorgh

The bones of this book belong to a poem I did not write. Sometime in the twelfth century, in the Persian city of Nishapur, a druggist and Sufi mystic named Farid al-Din Attar composed a poem called *Mantiq al-Tayr* — *The Conference of the Birds* — and I have been quietly stealing from it, I think, since long before I understood I was writing a novel that would need it.

The premise is deceptively simple. The birds of the world gather because they have no king. A hoopoe — wise, well-traveled, chosen because the Quran already tells us it once carried messages between Solomon and the Queen of Sheba — tells them they do have one: a king called the Simorgh, who lives on a mountain at the edge of the world. The birds are eager, briefly, until each of them remembers what it would have to leave behind to go looking. The nightingale won't abandon the rose. The parrot won't leave its cage, gilded as it is. The hawk is too fond of the falconer's wrist, the duck too fond of the water, the partridge too fond of the jewels it has learned to love more than flight. Every excuse a bird offers is, on inspection, a small and completely reasonable argument for staying exactly who you already are.

The hoopoe answers every excuse with a story instead of an argument, and eventually enough birds set out that a journey happens. It is not a kind journey. It runs through seven valleys — Search, Love, Insight, Detachment, Unity, Bewilderment, and finally Poverty and Annihilation — and most of the flock dies, or turns back, or simply stops being able to tell the difference between the two. Only thirty birds reach the mountain. They arrive expecting a throne. What they find instead is a mirrored lake, and their own reflections, and a pun patient enough to have waited the whole poem to be spoken aloud: in Persian, *si morgh* means *thirty birds*. It is also, spoken slightly differently, the name of the king they crossed the world to find. The birds were never following the Simorgh. They were the Simorgh, assembled, the entire time — a fact that was only ever going to become visible once enough of them had survived long enough, and lost enough of themselves, to be counted together.

I have never been able to decide whether that ending is the kindest or the cruelest thing a poem has ever done to its own characters, and I have come to suspect that the uncertainty is the point. Attar isn't offering the birds a reward for the journey. He's dissolving the premise that sent them on it — the idea that the self doing the seeking and the self being sought were ever two different things

requiring a bridge between them. That is the specific, difficult, very old idea this book has been trying to smuggle into a noir detective story about a man auditing his own memory: not that Rook will find out who he really is, but that the question was building a wall where there was never a river.

It should not have taken me as long as it did to notice that *si morph* was already the shape of my own plot before I ever gave it a name on the page. Cale Rook spends most of this book believing he is one bird, alone, trying to determine whether he is the original or a copy — a question with exactly two possible answers, both of them lonely. He is not one bird. He is, by the time the seven valleys are behind him, a small flock that happens to have been issued a single set of eyes: a dead auditor's habits, a dying boy's grandmother, an unauthorized brother kept alive in the one place a Reconciler's badge would never think to search. The king Rook goes looking for at the far side of the Memory Land was never separate from the griefs he was carrying to find it. It was those griefs, arranged in the right light, and finally willing to be counted as one thing instead of three.

This is, I think, why the poem insists on a hoopoe rather than a nightingale or a hawk to lead the others. The hoopoe is not the strongest bird in Attar's flock, or the most beautiful, or even the bravest. It is simply the one already accustomed to

carrying messages between people who cannot otherwise speak to each other — between Solomon and a queen who does not yet believe in his god, between the world above ground and the water it cannot see. The Guide who meets Rook at the gate of the Memory Land, who takes his shadow and tells him almost nothing and points, when pressed, only at the moon, is doing the same unglamorous work. He is not the answer. He is only willing to keep walking toward it long after the birds who wanted a shortcut have turned back.

I don't think the seven valleys are a map of suffering you're meant to endure once and be done with, any more than I think Rook's audit ends the day he closes his file. *Fana* — the annihilation Attar's birds finally reach, past even bewilderment — is not a door that locks behind you. It is closer to a room you learn the way back to, the way you learn the way back to any house you've grieved in more than once. What survives the crossing, for Attar's birds and for Rook alike, is not a purified, singular self finally cleared of everyone else's fingerprints. It is a self that has stopped needing to be singular in order to be real — thirty griefs, or two, or however many happened to be sharing a wall that particular year, counted together at last, and answering, when asked, to the same patient name.

— Chew Z.

*This edition of The Memory Liturgy was set for a reader
who, like its narrator, has learned that the difference
between
an original and a faithful continuity matters less than the
will
to carry a memory forward honestly.*

A NOTE FROM THE AUTHOR

This book was born from a question that kept returning in sleepless moments: what if the stories we tell about ourselves are buildings — and what if, one day, we're asked to walk the lower floors we've kept locked for years?

The Memory Liturgy follows a man who does this for a living. He decides whose memories are real, whose debts are owed, whose truth gets to remain. Then he receives a photograph of himself — and seven months he cannot remember.

As he crosses into a hidden country built from grief and forgetting, Cale Rook learns that identity is not discovered. It is negotiated. That the people who witnessed us honestly are the only ones who can call us back when we lose the way to our own name.

This is a noir about memory as currency, about the mercy we trade, and about the cost of forgetting what we promised to remember.

**EVERY MEMORY YOU DENY DOES NOT DISAPPEAR.
SOMEONE PAYS THE DEBT. THIS IS THEIR STORY.**

